
Furman Young Democratic Socialists of America

CONSTITUTION

Updated 3/20/2024

ARTICLE I: NAME AND AFFILIATION

1. The name of the organization shall be Furman Young Democratic Socialists of America, hereafter referred to as “the Chapter.”
2. The Chapter shall be the Furman chapter of Young Democratic Socialists of America, the youth wing of Democratic Socialists of America.

ARTICLE II: PURPOSE & MISSION STATEMENT

1. Our mission is to educate and organize students and young people and to play a helpful and principled role in the movement for social justice. Within and throughout this struggle, we will articulate and defend the idea that true human liberation is impossible under capitalism. We seek social change which extends democracy into all aspects of life—social, political and economic. This is the struggle for democratic socialism. Our vision of socialism is profoundly democratic, feminist, and anti-racist.

ARTICLE III: MEMBERSHIP

1. In keeping with Furman University’s non-discrimination policies, membership shall be open to all students. Our organization will not discriminate on the basis of race, sex, handicap, age, sexual orientation, political affiliation, or religious affiliation.
2. Membership is defined by affiliated individuals who have attended at least one meeting per semester, not including meetings set aside for the election of officers.

ARTICLE IV: CENTRAL COMMITTEE & DUTIES

1. The Central Committee shall be composed of two (2) Co-Chairs, one (1) Secretary, one (1) Treasurer
 - a. The Chapter may elect a Vice-Chair by special election if circumstances require.
2. To be eligible for the Central Committee, candidates must be dues-paying or dues-waived members of YDSA.
3. Candidates will nominate themselves no later than one week prior to the date of the election.
 - a. In the event of a special election, the Central Committee will issue a final call for nominations immediately prior to the commencement of voting at the meeting where the election is scheduled to take place. Candidates may nominate themselves as late as this final call.
4. Elections shall occur on a meeting date during the last full month of the Spring semester.
5. All elections shall be first-past-the-post.
 - a. In the event that no candidate reaches a majority, a runoff between the candidates with the highest vote totals will take place immediately afterwards.
 - b. In the event of a tie, successive votes will be held until a winner is determined.

- c. Co-Chairs will be elected on two separate ballots.
- 6. The term of the Central Committee shall begin with the closure of the final meeting of the spring semester and last until the end of the following academic year.
 - a. Central Committee vacancies shall be filled via special election, to be announced within one week of a Central Committee seat becoming vacant, and held no later than two weeks after the announcement.
 - b. At the end of an officer's term in office, all information and resources pertaining to the operation of the Chapter are to be turned over to the incoming officer-elect. The same principle shall apply to all information and resources jointly managed by the Central Committee.
- 7. Central Committee members may be subject to recall by petition with signatures of one-third ($\frac{1}{3}$) of the chapter's membership. Submission of such a valid petition shall trigger a recall election to be held no later than 30 days from receipt of that petition by the Central Committee. The meeting for a recall vote shall be properly noticed to the membership.
- 8. The duties of the Central Committee at large shall be:
 - a. To meet approximately once weekly, to the best ability of all members and with exceptions made for school holidays.
 - b. To meet in extraordinary sessions when the need arises.
 - c. To ensure the efficient and healthy functioning of the Chapter.
 - d. To act as model representatives of the Chapter and of socialism in general.
- 9. The duties of the Co-Chairs shall be:
 - a. To facilitate meetings
 - b. To reserve space for meetings, events, and tabling
 - c. To communicate with members of the YDSA National Coordinating Committee, staff, and members of YDSA's national subcommittees
 - d. To attend any school functions mandatory for organization presidents
 - e. To write monthly, though more frequently is encouraged, updates to send via email to everyone on the organization's email list
- 10. The duties of the Vice-Chair shall be:
 - a. To assist the Co-Chairs in their responsibilities and be prepared to be delegated some responsibilities of the Co-Chairs
 - b. To fulfill the Co-Chairs' responsibilities in absence of the Co-Chairs
 - c. To fill in for other officers in their absence, when necessary
- 11. The duties of the Secretary shall be:
 - a. To take minutes at general meetings
 - b. To send meeting minutes to everyone on the organization's email list within twenty-four (24) hours of a meeting's end
 - c. To maintain a list of active members and build an email list
 - d. To send weekly to bi-weekly email updates written by the Co-Chairs to membership
- 12. The duties of the Treasurer shall be:
 - a. To manage any funds of the organization
 - b. To maintain an active log of the chapter's income and expenditures
 - c. To fill out school grant request forms when necessary
 - d. To serve as lead organizer for one (1) fundraiser per academic semester
- 13. It shall be within the rights of The Chapter, by a majority vote, to render endorsements for candidates

in Furman Student Government Association elections or elections for offices within whose geographical constituency Furman University falls.

- a. The Chapter shall not be required to render an endorsement in any election if it does not see fit.
- b. All candidates endorsed by The Chapter must explicitly and publicly endorse the Chapter's Campus Program (for SGA candidates) or DSA's platform (for candidates for public office). This requirement may not be waived by a majority vote of either the Central Committee or the Chapter at large.
- c. Any member who wishes for the Chapter to change its endorsement or non-endorsement of a particular candidate may initiate a petition, which, if approved by one-third (1/3rd) of the membership, will trigger a Chapter-wide endorsement vote. The Chapter will be compelled to contact a candidate approved for endorsement by this method and attempt to solicit an endorsement of the Campus Program or DSA's platform.

ARTICLE V: COMMITTEES & WORKING GROUPS

1. It shall be within the power of the chapter to create subsidiary bodies to oversee and coordinate certain areas of organizing work.
2. These bodies shall fall into two categories, "committees" and "working groups."
 - a. Committees shall exist to oversee broad areas of organizing and coordinate projects in those areas.
 - i. Committees may be created by a simple majority vote of the general body at a general body meeting.
 - b. Working groups shall exist to facilitate ground-level organizing of specific projects.
 - i. Working groups may be created by a simple majority vote of the general body, or by a simple majority vote of the Central Committee.
3. Committees and working groups must meet on a regular schedule.
 - a. Meetings should meet a quorum of a majority of the active membership of the body.
 - b. Meetings should produce concrete action items and minutes.
 - i. Minutes shall be sent to the Central Committee within 48 hours.
4. All working groups must be attached to one committee, and each working group is to be represented on its committee by one person for every three active members.
 - a. Three active members shall be the minimum size for a working group, and any group which falls below three active members shall be considered an inactive working group.
 - i. Active members of working groups are those who have been present at two consecutive meetings of the working group.
5. Committees shall consist of representatives of their constituent working groups, as well as one at-large member appointed by the Central Committee.
 - a. Appointments may be overridden by a simple majority vote of the general body at a general body meeting.
6. Committees shall appoint, by a simple majority vote, a committee chair to act as a public point of contact for the committee, who shall be responsible for:
 - a. Reporting from the committee at weekly Central Committee meetings.
 - b. Reporting from the Central Committee at regular committee meetings.

- c. Communicating with the general body on behalf of the committee.
 - d. Facilitating meetings of the committee
- 7. Committees and working groups shall appoint, by a simple majority vote, one member to act as a secretary.
 - a. Committee and working group secretaries shall be responsible for taking minutes during meetings and sending minutes to the Central Committee.
- 8. All subsidiary bodies of the chapter shall follow the democratic decisions of higher bodies, while retaining the right of appeal.
 - a. Working groups shall follow the democratic decisions of their parent committees, committees those of the Central Committee, and the Central Committee those of the general body.

ARTICLE VI: CAMPUS PROGRAM

- 1. Upon its election, the founding Central Committee will be compelled to draft a Campus Program detailing the immediate and long-term goals of the Chapter's activities at Furman.
- 2. The Campus Program, hereafter referred to as the Program, should reflect the emancipatory horizons of socialism and be practically oriented towards the Chapter's position at Furman.
- 3. The Program will be subject to ratification by the entire Chapter at the first meeting of every academic year.
 - a. All revisions to the Program must be presented to the general membership for ratification at the next Chapter-wide meeting.

ARTICLE VII: FUNDING

- 1. The organization shall be funded through the following means: fundraisers, chapter dues, and contributions and scholarships from Democratic Socialists of America.
- 2. All money transactions must be approved by the Treasurer.
- 3. The Central Committee shall maintain a record of all financial transactions and accounts. These records shall be made available at any time by the request of any YDSA national officer and will be reported regularly to the membership of the Chapter.

ARTICLE VIII: MEETINGS

- 1. Regular meetings of the organization shall be held weekly. The day of the week and time will be determined at the beginning of every semester.
 - a. Meeting times may be changed by two-thirds ($\frac{2}{3}$) vote of membership
- 2. Special meetings may be called by the Central Committee. Votes and elections may not occur at such meetings.
- 3. Agendas for meetings shall be prepared by the Central Committee and will be available at the request of members before a meeting.
- 4. A quorum for any meeting shall be one-half ($\frac{1}{2}$) of members.

ARTICLE IX: POWERS

- 1. The Chapter shall have special committees created if deemed necessary by membership. The formation of such committees shall be approved by a majority vote of the membership at a regular meeting.

2. The Chapter shall operate as a non-profit association and no profits may accrue to any individual within the organization.
3. Unless otherwise provided in these bylaws, decisions of the organization shall be made by a simple majority of those present and voting, with those abstaining from the vote not figuring into the determination of the majority required.
4. For purposes of any vote, the determination of the current eligible voting membership shall be a private ballot (likely a folded index card or piece of paper). Votes will be counted immediately by the Central Committee in the presence of members.
5. The rules contained in the simplified edition of Robert's Rules of Order Newly Revised (as appended below) shall govern the Chapter in all cases to which they are applicable and in which they are not inconsistent with this Constitution, the Bylaws, or standing rules of the organization.
 - a. [Robert's Rules \[LINK\]](#)

ARTICLE X: AMENDMENT OF BYLAWS

1. These bylaws may be amended at any regular meeting of the organization by a two-thirds ($\frac{2}{3}$) vote, provided that the amendment has been submitted in writing to the Central Committee at the previous regular meeting or a week prior to the applicable meeting.

ARTICLE XI: HARASSMENT AND GRIEVANCE POLICY

1. The chapter shall follow [DSA's Harassment Policy](#) and seek to uphold [DSA's Code of Conduct](#).
2. The chapter shall provide a confidential method for chapter members to report grievances, through at least two Harassment and Grievance Officers (HGOs).
 - a. To be eligible to serve as an HGO, candidates must be chapter members, receive a nomination from another chapter member, and go through a vetting process. HGOs may not be members of a sitting Central Committee.
 - b. The preferred names and contact information of HGOs shall be available at all times to chapter members and routinely shared at regular meetings.
 - c. The chapter shall appoint HGOs to serve regular annual terms concurrent with the Central Committee.
 - d. The chapter shall aim to appoint members of marginalized communities to the HGO position.
3. The chapter's grievance process shall aim to uphold principles of fairness, inclusivity and respect for all parties. The chapter HGO shall document each step of the process and report to the central committee only when their decision on disciplinary action is necessary and confidentiality can be ensured.
4. In the event that member(s) of the Central Committee are mentioned in an HGO incident report, the member(s) in question and those deemed at the discretion of the HGO to be close personal associates thereof will be compelled to recuse themselves from all votes pertaining to the incident.
 - a. In such a situation, an ad hoc committee consisting of the remaining Central Committee members will convene to hear the HGO's report.
 - b. Vacancies left by recused Central Committee members will be filled by random selection of members of the Chapter not mentioned in the incident report.

ARTICLE XII: DISSOLUTION CLAUSE

1. Should the organization be dissolved due to lack of interest or other reasons, it is the responsibility of

the current Co-Chairs to notify the Student Government Alliance that they have disbanded and provide reason. The treasurer is responsible for ensuring all fundraising dollars go to Democratic Socialists of America and notifying the SGA that any allocated funding left will not be used.